

Control Imperative

The Internet is out of control, with dangerous people spreading dangerous lies. But our Department of Information Technology can fix all that. Internet censorship has finally arrived at our doorstep.

The Internet is a collection, in David Weinberger's words, of "small pieces loosely joined". Closing access to a small section of the Internet is like grasping a fistful of water—the only way to do it is to build an information dam. China seems to be doing it well, maybe our ministries could take a few pointers from the dragon next door.

In an attempt to block one message board hosted on the Yahoo! Groups service, all Indians have been denied Web access to the entire service. Our ISPs are not equipped to block one section of a site, so in order to comply with the government directive they went the extra distance and blocked the entire site. Ironically, Yahoo! India mirrors the Groups service, so we still have access on another URL. If you had set the group to e-mail messages to you, you would get those too. And this does not count the free services that would let you bypass this simple-minded, clumsy attempt at censorship. Of course, this action has been a wonderful concentrator of world attention, and this obscure group with 3 messages a month and less than 30 subscribers is now on the Internet map for millions.

There certainly are problems associated with Internet anarchy. Unsavory, unwanted messages from around the world already clog every e-mail box, and once we begin to turn to the convenience of an online economy, we too will be afflicted with the troubles that afflict our Western brethren. Scams and identity theft are inevitable and we certainly need the policing, but is isolationism the solution?

The Internet only reflects what we see in the real world—calls for revolution included. Underlying this attempt at silencing dissent is the implicit assumption that we need to be 'protected' from misinformation. Hopefully, this fiasco will drive home the point that misinformation can only be fought with the truth, not blinkers.



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